

# ChangHo on the charge

ChangHo Lee made a **stunning UFC debut**, securing a dominant TKO win. With 11 wins in 12 fights, he's South Korea's next MMA hope.

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**S**outh Korea's presence in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) has been limited.

Its most accomplished fighter, Dong Hyun Kim (22-4-1), faded from the scene after a loss to former interim welterweight champion Colby Covington in 2017. However, that narrative may be about to change.

ChangHo Lee, the latest South Korean to join the promotion, made an emphatic statement in his UFC debut. The 30-year-old secured a dominant technical knockout victory over the USA's Cortavious Romious at UFC Fight Night in Nevada, which earned him a 'Fight of the Night' bonus.

The Road to UFC Season 2 bantamweight champion capitalised on Romious's over-aggression in both the first and second rounds. Lee's constant, rapid movement proved too much for the American, who struggled to maintain

his defence and was soon nursing a bloodied eyebrow. From then on, it was carnage.

**Late in the second round, Lee spotted an opening, took Romious to the ground, and unleashed a relentless barrage of elbows to claim his maiden UFC victory.**

In an interview, Lee revealed that he admires former UFC champion Khabib Nurmagomedov and strives to incorporate elements of Khabib's cage wrestling, grappling, and chain wrestling into his own style. Though the sample size was small, glimpses of Khabib's aggression and technique were evident in Lee's performance.

Lee earned his place in the UFC with two emphatic victories in Road to UFC Season 2. In the quarterfinals, he dismantled India's Rana Rudra Pratap Singh with a first-round knockout via strikes.

However, his first real test came against China's Daermisi Zhawupasi, a submission specialist. Daermisi controlled the early minutes of the fight with relentless grappling and came close to securing a rear-naked choke. Lee, however, managed to escape.

The decisive moment arrived in the final minutes of the third round. Lee pinned Daermisi against the cage, forced him to the ground, and finished the fight with a fierce display of ground and pound.

He then secured a split-decision victory over China's Xiao Long, earning himself a UFC contract.

Despite entering the UFC at a relatively late stage in his career, Lee has already made a strong impression on both fans and analysts. With 11 wins from 12 professional fights, he has built a formidable reputation. How far he can go in the UFC remains to be seen — but he is certainly one to watch.

**No mercy:** ChangHo Lee unleashed a flurry of elbows to secure a statement win in his first UFC fight. GETTY IMAGES

